

Lawyer who used N-word about colleague was spared suspension

BY TORIANO PORTER
tporter@kcsstar.com

The Missouri Supreme Court dropped the ball. The state’s highest court had a chance to make a profound statement against racist behavior within the Missouri Bar Association but instead let Platte City defense attorney Scott Campbell escape meaningful repercussions for calling Platte County Assistant Prosecutor Lynnette Lockhart, a Black woman, the N-word. In a ruling issued April 21, the state Supreme Court found Campbell guilty of professional misconduct for using a racial epithet (the N word) in reference to Lockhart. As a result, Campbell received a six-month sus-

pension and fined \$1,500. However, the high court stayed the suspension and placed Campbell on probation for six months, meaning he can still practice law while on probation. Don’t get me wrong here: Campbell isn’t completely off the hook. According to stipulations of his probation, the defense attorney must walk a fine line for the next six months and stay clear of legal trouble and civil claims against him. He cannot run afoul of professional rules of conduct for attorneys, either. If he violates any conditions of the probation — and there are many — he could, in fact, face a suspension or worse. Lockhart, an adjunct law professor at the University of Missouri-Kansas

City has almost two decades of experience practicing law and spent nearly a decade in the U.S. Army. In a statement sent to me, Lockhart said she respects the Missouri Supreme Court’s decision. “My focus has always been on upholding the standards of this profession and making sure those standards are clear for lawyers of all backgrounds, and for my students who are preparing to enter this field,” Lockhart wrote. After reading the ruling, I could only ask one question: How is this outcome even remotely fair? Any lawyer that uses such reprehensible language deserves the strongest punishment possible outside of losing their law license. In this case, the state

Supreme Court’s ruling deserves to be scrutinized — and this is not a personal attack on the judges who heard the case. I would hate to be accused of bad-mouthing the state’s highest court because of a ruling I didn’t agree with. In Missouri, the state Supreme Court determines punishment for attorneys found guilty of professional conduct. Because of conflicts of interest, Kathleen Hamilton, a judge on the Missouri Court of Appeals, Eastern District, and Bryan E. Nickell, a judge on the Missouri Court of Appeals, Southern District, were appointed special judges to replace Chief Justice W. Brent Powell and Supreme Court Judge Zel Fischer during oral

arguments heard April 14, according to court records. Powell was assistant prosecuting attorney in Platte County from 1997 to 2001, according to his bio and Fischer has been a member of the Platte County Bar Association, according to the Supreme Court’s website. Campbell has been licensed to practice law since 1990, according to the Missouri Bar’s website. **‘ISOLATED REMARK; ‘MISGUIDED OVERREACTION’** Attorneys for Campbell and the Missouri Office of Chief Disciplinary Counsel argued before Hamilton, Nickell and Robin Ransom, acting Supreme Court chief justice, court records indicate. I reached out to Mis-

souri Supreme Court spokeswoman Beth Riggert to get a better understanding of the ruling, but she declined to comment. “I have no way of interpreting the court’s ruling,” Riggert said in a brief phone conversation. But a case summary does provide a glimpse of how the high court came to its decision. In the ruling, Ransom cited previous decisions made by the court, American Bar Association standards for imposing lawyer discipline, and aggravating and mitigating circumstances in issuing the stay. Messages sent to Campbell and his attorneys James Morrow and Connor DeWitt seeking comment were not returned. Court records indicate that Campbell was in good standing with the Missouri Bar and his conduct was an isolated incident, Morrow argued. “In light of the uncontroverted relationship between Mr. Campbell and Ms. Lockhart, and the

SEE PORTER, 12A



The traveling “Exhibition of Archaeological Finds of the People’s Republic of China” opened up new worlds in the heartland. Star file photo

Nelson-Atkins 1975 Chinese art exhibit still resonates in Kansas City today

BY JIM U’REN
Special to The Kansas City Star

In the spring of 1975, I was a 20-something economics student at the University of Missouri-Kansas City, living with my wife in an apartment on Rockhill Road, two blocks north of one of the finest art museums in the

country. The William Rockhill Nelson Gallery of Art and Atkins Museum of Fine Arts, now the Nelson-Atkins Museum of Art, was just a short walk from our door. I passed it every day on my way to classes. We enjoyed living next door to a museum of this stature. When word came in early 1975 that an in-

ternational exhibition would soon open at the Nelson-Atkins, we had no idea how fortunate we were — to find ourselves two blocks from a once-in-a-generation show, to witness a cultural event of historic significance, and to get a chance to work behind the scenes at the Nelson-Atkins. That spring, the Nelson

Gallery became the second American stop for “The Exhibition of Archaeological Finds of the People’s Republic of China,” a sweeping, landmark show of cultural treasures from the East. After opening in Paris, the exhibit traveled to London, Vienna, Stockholm and Toronto before reaching Washington, D.C.

Kansas City prepared for a seven-week engagement, and in the weeks leading up, the anticipation steadily grew. The collection arrived in early April 1975, in the midst of the Cold War and at a moment when official U.S. policy toward China began to pivot. Americans were curious and intrigued by a civilization that had been, for a generation, mostly invisible to Western eyes. The ancient artifacts, jade ornaments, silk textiles and bronze sculptures were not merely beautiful objects — they were dispatches from another world, arriving at a moment when the distance between worlds was, for the first time in decades, beginning to close. Word spread around the UMKC campus that the Nelson sought extra staff for the exhibition. I jumped at the chance to work at the museum around the corner, rushed to fill out an application, and got an interview within a few days. When I arrived, a dignified, nicely dressed woman greeted me. She looked me over with calm, appraising eyes and said simply: “Follow me.” For the next two hours, she conducted an interview while we did light gardening on the south side of the Museum — deadheading flowers, pulling the occasional weed, moving through the well-maintained garden at an unhurried pace while she asked her questions. The interview ranks as the most unusual I have ever had, before or since.

PAINTING OVER VISITOR SMUDGES ON GALLERY WALLS She seemed pleasant but measured as she asked me the typical interview questions in this atypical setting. At one point, she stopped, turned to me, and said plainly: “You know, this is not just another after-hours janitorial job. This is the Chinese exhibit at the Nelson-Atkins.” I nodded and thought, good. I didn’t want a janitorial job — I wanted to work inside this museum. She had read through my application and noted that I had some interior painting experience from summer jobs. She explained that touch-up painting of the exhibit walls would be part of the work, and then asked me a question I never expected: Did I know how to paint with a dry brush? I responded I had been taught: Never paint with a dry brush. A dry brush leaves streaks and misses. She nodded as if she had expected that answer. Then she explained that the exhibit walls needed to look perfect when the doors opened each morning, but the large numbers of visitors were leaving marks, smudges and fingerprints. Normal cleaning solutions did more harm than good. Paint was needed to cover the traffic marks, but it needed to be fully dry before the first visitors arrived. The dry brush technique required a deliberate and precise touch — with barely any paint on the brush, just enough to cover a smudge or a fingerprint, working

SEE U’REN, 12A

Missouri has a deadly speeding problem. Here’s the right solution

BY ASIA DUNMORE
Special to The Kansas City Star

On Oct. 14, 2023, my mother Michelle Dunmore was walking to a bus stop on Troost Avenue in Kansas City when a driver hit her and kept going. My mother was and will forever be 59 years old. She was her mother’s only child, a daughter, a mother and also a grandmother. She was a caregiver for my children and a light in

our lives. The driver, just 20 years old, later admitted she had been speeding and was not paying attention to the road. She hit my mother, did not render aid, drove away — and acted like my mother’s life didn’t matter. My mother did not have to die in that very tragic way. The driver chose to speed. She chose not to stop. Those decisions were made by a person who had decided that the rules did

not apply to her, and my mother paid for them with her life. In the two years since, I’ve learned that this kind of recklessness is not unusual. It is tragically common on Missouri’s roads. According to the Missouri Coalition for Roadway Safety, excessive speed is the single most common factor in Missouri fatal crashes. Speed is involved in 36% of all traffic fatalities, and cited twice as often as impaired driving.

In 2023 alone, 359 Missourians were killed in speed-related crashes, and unfortunately my mother was one of those numbers. These are not abstract numbers. They are mothers and grandmothers. Fathers and grandfathers. Sons and daughters. They are people who left home and never came back. **TARGET DRIVERS WITH REVOKED LICENSES** Missouri legislators are considering a bill that takes direct aim at the most dangerous speeders on our roads. House Bill 3317 would give habitual speeders a path to getting their license back, but

only if they agree to install an intelligent speed assistance device on every vehicle they drive. The bill targets drivers whose licenses have been revoked because of repeated speeding violations. Intelligent speed assistance mechanisms use location-based technology to prevent a vehicle from exceeding the posted limit. If you have one of these devices installed on your vehicle, it works to prevent you from going 70 in a 50-mph zone. Some will ask whether that means the government is tracking their movements. It does not: The device uses location

data only to verify speed limits and detect tampering — not to monitor where you go or report your whereabouts to the government. This is not a mandate on ordinary drivers. It does not affect anyone who has not already lost their license because of a pattern of dangerous speeding. It is a targeted, proportionate response to a specific, small group of drivers who have already demonstrated, through their repeated behavior, that fines and warnings have not been enough to prevent them from be-

SEE DUNMORE, 12A

THE KANSAS CITY STAR.

A paper for all the people.

Andale Gross
Executive Editor

Hannah Wise
Managing Editor

Ian Cummings
Managing Editor

Stephanie Boggins
Vice President, Advertising

Jane Howard
Vice President, Advertising Operations

Heather Williams
Vice President, Audience

Yvette Walker
Vice President, Opinion Editor

EDITORIAL BOARD
Yvette Walker, Derek Donovan, Toriano Porter

Customer Service
1-877-962-STAR (7827)
customerservice@kcsstar.com

Opinion content from syndicated sources may be trimmed from the original length to fit available space.

To send letters: Visit KansasCity.com/letters to submit your letter to the editor of 200 words or fewer. You may also mail your submission to Letters to the Editor, The Kansas City Star, 5151 Merriam Drive, Merriam, Kansas 66203. Include your address and phone number for verification only. **Guest columns:** The Star welcomes exclusive essays of up to 600 words. Email the essay and a photo of the author to oped@kcsstar.com. All submissions are edited before publication.